Updates for the 2026 Alaska Wide Sablefish Assessment CIE Review

The documents associated with the review are available for download from the CIE GitHub Repo and associated Google Drive. There has been a slight update to the list of documents for review, as a new *draft* Stock Assessment and Fishery Evaluation (SAFE) report was created, which is the primary document for review. The SAFE summarizes input data, model structure, and outputs for two sablefish assessment models: Model *26.1_1Reg* (a single region panmictic assessment) and Model *26.2_FAA* (a spatially implicit fleets-as-areas assessment that disaggregates the NOAA Longline Survey into regional fleets – Bering Sea, Aleutian Islands, and Gulf of Alaska – to deal with recent extensive survey design changes). The main goal of the review is to provide recommendations on which model structure provides the best scientific basis for developing operational management advice for sablefish in 2026 and beyond. The CIE review meeting will be structured around comparing and contrasting performance of these two model structures.

Five appendices were developed that summarize different aspects of model building, which should provide additional context for understanding the two models presented in the main SAFE document. These include a summary of the SPoRC assessment framework and model structure (Appendix 3A), single region model changes since 2025 (Appendix 3B), fleets-as-areas (FAA) model development (Appendix 3C), summary of spatial models (3D), and a summary of a spatially explicit closed loop simulation that was used to inform model structure decisions (Appendix 3E). All of the appendices are meant as sources of additional information for understanding the decisions regarding model structure in the main SAFE document.

Additional sablefish background documents, which may be of interest but are not part of the review requirements, have been uploaded (available here). Within the background documents, the assessment documents folder will be of particular value for understanding previous modeling decisions (in particular Goethel and Cheng, 2025, describing changes to the model implemented in 2025). The data and model files (R files) used to run the assessment in SPoRC as well as model outputs are available on the GitHub repo (here). If there are any questions about models, files, or repo organization, please contact the lead assessment author (Dan Goethel, daniel.goethel@noaa.gov).

The final documents for review by the CIE include:

For Review (available here)

- **2026 Assessment of the Sablefish Stock in Alaska: 2026 Center for Independent Experts (CIE) Review Document (here)**
- **Appendix 3A. The Spatial Population over Regional Components (SPoRC) Model: Technical Description of the Assessment Model for Sablefish (here)**
- **Appendix 3B. Model Building and Bridging Exercise for the Sablefish Single Region Models (Bridging from Model *25.12* to *26.1_1Reg*) (here)**
- **Appendix 3C. Development of a Fleets-as-Areas (FAA) Stock Assessment Model for Alaska Sablefish (*Model 26.2_FAA*) (here)**
- **Appendix 3D. Results of Spatial Stock Assessment Models for Alaska Sablefish (here)**
- **Appendix 3E. Evaluating Alternative Assessment Structures for Alaska Sablefish Under Survey Design Changes via Closed-Loop Simulation (here)**

Tasks for Reviewers

As a reminder, the overarching goals of this review process are to:

1. Ensure the FAA stock assessment supports the development of robust advice for use by the North Pacific Fishery Management Council based on the BSIA;
2. Provide an independent external review of this stock assessment to confirm that it meets the mandates of the Magnuson-Stevens Fisheries Conservation and Management Act (MSA) and other legal requirements;
3. Understand and identify appropriate FAA model structure and fits to key data sources (indices, landings, and age compositions);
4. Identify research needed to improve the assessment and advice for fishery managers.

Pre-review Background Documents:
A minimum of two weeks before the peer review, the NOAA Fisheries Project Contact will provide the CIE reviewers the necessary background information and reports for the peer review (review documents here). The CIE reviewers are responsible only for the pre-review documents that are delivered to the reviewer in accordance with the PWS scheduled deadlines specified herein. The CIE reviewers *must review* all of the review documents in preparation for the peer review, as these contain the results of the primary analyses and model runs that will be discussed during the review panel. Please note that outputs of all analyses used as part of the CIE review, including input data, simulation outputs, final proposed assessment models, and all sensitivity assessment models, will be made available on the sablefish CIE GitHub repository

Within two weeks of award	Contractor secures participation of the CIE reviewers.
At least two weeks prior to the panel review meeting	Pre-review documents are provided to the reviewers.
June 16 - 18, 2026	The reviewers participate and conduct an independent peer review during the panel review meeting.
Approximately 2 weeks later	Contractor receives draft reports.
Within 3 weeks of receiving draft reports	Contractor submits final reports to the US Government.

Annex 1: Peer Review Report Requirements

1. The CIE independent report shall be prefaced with an Executive Summary providing a concise summary of the findings and recommendations as specified in the ToR and specify whether the science reviewed is the best scientific information available.

2. The main body of the reviewer report shall consist of the following sections: Background; Description of the Individual Reviewer's Role in the Review Activities; Summary of Findings for each ToR in which the weaknesses and strengths are described; and Conclusions and Recommendations in accordance with the ToRs.

    a. Each reviewer should describe in their own words the review activities completed during the panel review meeting, including providing a brief summary of findings as well as the science, conclusions, and recommendations.

    b. Each reviewer should discuss their independent views on each ToR even if these were consistent with those of other panelists, and especially where there were divergent views.

    c. Each reviewer should elaborate on any points that they feel might require further clarification.

    d. Each independent CIE report shall be a stand-alone document through which others can understand the weaknesses and strengths of the science reviewed and shall be an independent peer review of each ToRs.

3. The reviewer report shall include the following appendices:

   Appendix 1: Bibliography of materials provided for review.
   Appendix 2: A copy of the CIE Performance Work Statement.
   Appendix 3: Panel Membership or other pertinent information from the panel review meeting.

Annex 2: Terms of Reference (ToRs) for the Peer Review

Review of the Alaska-wide Sablefish Assessment

CIE reviewers are contracted to complete their independent peer review based on the ToRs. Therefore, the CIE-NOAA Fisheries review and approval process is based on whether the CIE independent reports addressed each of the ToRs.

1) Review the disseminated documents and analyses, then provide feedback on whether the fleets-as-areas (FAA) assessment provides a suitable basis for operational management advice, particularly in comparison to the current single region panmictic assessment.
   a) Provide recommendations on the most appropriate parametrization of fleet structure (number of fleets per fishery/survey, as a proxy for regions) in the FAA model.

2) Highlight potential strengths and weaknesses of the FAA assessment, including model assumptions, estimates, fits to data (survey indices and age compositions along with fishery catch-at-age data), model diagnostics, and major sources of uncertainty.
   a) Indicate whether the model provides the best scientific information available for estimating current stock status, projecting future abundance, and determining Overfishing Levels (OFLs) and Acceptable Biological Catches (ABCs).

3) Provide research recommendations for improving the existing research-oriented sablefish spatial (i.e., 3 and 5 region) assessment models, especially in the context of potential future usage in a management context.

Reviewers must provide details for the basis of their responses to the review ToRs.

Tentative Agenda for the CIE Review of the Alaska-wide Sablefish Assessment

North Pacific Fishery Management Council
NOAA Alaska Fisheries Science Center, Auke Bay Laboratories
17109 Pt. Lena Loop Road
Juneau, AK 99801

June 16-18, 2026

Contact: Chris Lunsford (Chris.Lunsford@noaa.gov)

Schedule

(this agenda is *DRAFT* and subject to change)

All times below are Alaska Daylight Time
Daily breaks at ~10:30 and ~15:30, Lunch 12:30-14:00
Tuesday-Thursday, 09:00 – 17:00 AKDT

Tuesday, June 16, 2026

A. **Welcome and Introductions (30min)**
B. **Sablefish Background (Management, Biology, and Data Inputs; 3hrs)**
C. **General Assessment Model Structure (ToR 1; 3hrs)**

Wednesday, June 17, 2026

A. **Reconvene and Review (30min)**
B. **Summary of Closed Loop Simulations (3hrs)**
C. **Comparing Assessment Performance and Diagnostics (ToRs 1/2; 3hrs)**

Thursday, June 18, 2026

A. **Reconvene and Review (30min)**
B. **Comparing Assessment Performance and Diagnostics *Cont'd* (ToR 1/2; 3hrs)**
C. **Spatial Model Configurations and Diagnostics (ToR 3; 3hrs)**

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